will. The Indian government was aware of these attacks, which included a cyber-strike to disable the country's national emergency response systems, and took pre-emptive action to thwart these groups successfully.

The Indian government did not confirm these cyber attacks till April 2022, when the US-based cyber security firm Recorded Future gave out details of the attack. The firm surmised that Internet Protocol (IP) cameras, often used in Close Circuit Television (CCTV) networks, and internet-operated Digital Video Recording (DVR) devices were compromised in the operation by the Chinese. The operation, they said, was an effort to collect information about India's power infrastructure. Soon after, the Centre confirmed that Indian power plants near the LAC were indeed a target, with Union power minister R.K. Singh saying that two Chinese hacking attempts on electricity distribution centres in Ladakh in 2021 were repelled. Singh told press reporters, "These were probing attacks and they failed because our defence against such cyber-attacks is strong."

The Chinese government vehemently denied such attacks, but it had sent alarm bells ringing across India's high security establishments and supercritical sectors like power and telecom. Especially after a quick estimate by the Indian government showed that there were over two million CCTVs installed across the country, with over 90 per cent of them made by Chinese companies that were partially owned by the Chinese government. Worryingly, over half of them were installed in government departments. This was confirmed by Sanjay Dhotre, the minister of state for communications and IT, when he informed the Lok Sabha in March 2021 that around one million Chinese-made CCTVs are installed in government institutions. "There are vulnerabilities associated with video data captured through CCTV cameras being transferred to servers located abroad," said an alarmed Dhotre. He had avoided mentioning China directly, but it was evident which country he was hinting at.

What is worrying is that experts point out that these CCTVs have weak technical architecture that can easily be compromised and used for offensive purposes. "You don't need to send spies across the border anymore—these CCTVs become the eyes of any country wanting to do mischief. They are the best tools to get techint (technical intelligence). The unchecked proliferation of such devices across the country is a serious security risk," Lt Gen. Rajesh Pant (retd), National Cyber Security Coordinator for the National Security Council at the prime minister's office, told INDIA TODAY. Pant said he had written to the Union ministry for home affairs (MHA) last month to issue a set of guidelines for the purchase of such equipment by any government department to prevent proliferation of unverified devices and to work out "remedial action" for those already installed. Currently, there is no nodal ministry that deals with the surveillance device issue.

The matter has gained urgency now after Australia and the UK banned imports of Chinese-made CCTVs for use in their respective government departments in quick succession in the past three months. In doing so, they joined the US, which had taken steps in this direction in 2019 itself and implemented a full ban in November 2022. Experts estimate the market penetration of such Chinese closed-circuit television cameras in India to be more than 80 per cent for domestic applications and more than 98 per cent for government installations—including military compounds and other high-security establishments. Mounted on eaves and cornices, and from atop walls, parapets and lampposts, they keep a constant eye on our activities, a crucial apparatus in this era of 24/7 surveillance. India's security experts fear that the potential loss of ultra-sensitive data by way of snooping through CCTVs has become a reality. The agent and beneficiary of such electronic espionage: our intransigent and hostile neighbour in the north and east, China.

**"THE UNCHECKED PROLIFERATION OF FOREIGN-MADE CCTV DEVICES ACROSS THE COUNTRY POSES A SERIOUS SECURITY RISK"**



**LT GEN. RAJESH PANT (RETD)**
*National Cyber Security Coordinator*

## CODE RED IN DEFENCE ESTABLISHMENTS

The National Security Council Secretariat (NSCS) and the Defence Intelligence Agency (DIA) have both raised concerns about the danger of data loss through surveillance cameras originating from China after it was revealed that they were installed in all Indian naval establishments. "Compromise of a CCTV system could also compromise the security of military establishments," claims a May 2021 internal note from the integrated defence headquarters of India's ministry of defence (MoD), seen by INDIA TODAY. Soon after, the southern naval command raised an alarm over Chinese CCTV cameras in its multiple lo-